small, lean and secure intelligence organisation, entirely in the public sector, than a large public-private hybrid that leaks.

The single biggest lesson of the whole Snowden fiasco is that America's own sloppiness made it vulnerable: whether to misguided whistleblowers, saboteurs or foreign spies is secondary. The intelligence agencies and their political and judicial overseers also need to do a much better job of explaining what they do and why. The best defence against a Snowden-style leak is a broad national consensus that the agencies are to be trusted and that the measures they take are necessary. Sweden is exemplary in this respect.

It is important not to concentrate the defence case too narrowly on terrorism. That is a grave threat, but not the only one. Invoking the attacks of September 11th 2001 as justification for everything the NSA does can be a powerful defence, but it wears out with over-use. It invites pointed questions, like how many terrorists did you catch by trawling meta-data? The answers may be elusive. It is much better to justify intelligence operations on a broad, prudential basis. A country like America faces a lot of threats and they are constantly changing. Good intelligence capabilities provide a well-stocked tool-kit for dealing with them. The traditional reluctance to discuss sources and methods, for fear of rendering them useless in future, is well founded. But in an atmosphere of suspicion, it is not wholly sustainable. Grim silence is not going to restore public trust. It may be necessary to sacrifice some degree of secrecy about past operations in order to win the backing needed for future ones.

Dissent within the espionage world needs to be better managed. Intelligence agencies are meant to be good at handling people. If your internal culture is strong and expert enough to recruit and run agents, it should be capable of managing your own staff too. If problems cannot be dealt with, the individual concerned must be